

Language

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- 5.1** Explain the symbolic, rule-based, subjective, culture-bound nature of language.
- 5.2** Recognize the impact, both positive and negative, of language in interpersonal relationships.
- 5.3** Describe the influence gender has on language use in interpersonal relationships.
- 5.4** Identify ways in which online language usage is different from the in-person variety.

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PROFESSOR LERA BORODITSKY (2009) often begins her undergraduate lectures by asking students which cognitive faculty they would least want to lose. Most choose vision; a few pick hearing. Almost no one mentions language.

Boroditsky suggests this is an oversight. After all, she reasons, people who lack the ability to see or hear can still have rich and satisfying lives. “But what would your life be like if you had never learned a language?” she wonders. “Could you still have friends, get an education, hold a job, start a family? Language is so fundamental to our experience, so deeply a part of being human, that it’s hard to imagine life without it” (p. 116).

A simple exercise illustrates how language is basic to our view of the world. Take a look at Figure 5.1 and quickly name aloud each of the colors of the words (for instance, you should say “orange, blue, yellow” when reading the first line). Chances are, you’ll have difficulty doing so without pausing or stumbling. This phenomenon, known as the Stroop effect, points to how language influences perception. We see the world through the filter of our words.

Language is arguably the most essential component of human communication. In this chapter, we explore the relationship between words and ideas. We describe some important characteristics of language and show how these characteristics affect our day-to-day communication. We outline several types of troublesome language and show how to replace them with more effective kinds of speech. Finally, we look at how gender and online communication influence the way we use language.

THE NATURE OF LANGUAGE

We begin our survey by looking at some features that characterize all languages. These features explain both why language is such a useful tool and why it can be so troublesome.

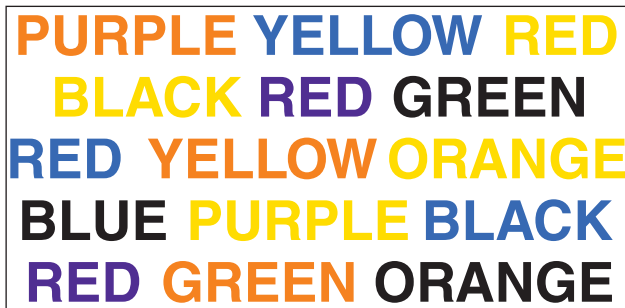


FIGURE 5.1 The Stroop Effect. Naming the color of a printed word is more difficult if the word meaning and the color do not match.

LANGUAGE IS SYMBOLIC

Words are arbitrary symbols that have no meaning in themselves. For example, the word *five* is a kind of code that represents the number of fingers on your hand only because we agree that it does. As Bateson and Jackson (1964) point out, “There is nothing particularly five-like in the number ‘five’” (p. 271). To a speaker of French, the symbol *cinq* would convey the same meaning; to a computer, the same value would be represented by the digitally coded symbol *0101*.

Even sign language, as “spoken” by most deaf people, is symbolic in nature (Sandler, 2013). Because this form of communication is symbolic and not literal, there are hundreds of different sign languages used around the world that have evolved independently, whenever significant numbers

of deaf people have come in contact (Meir et al., 2010). These distinct languages include American Sign Language, Mexican Sign Language, British Sign Language, French Sign Language, Danish Sign Language, Chinese Sign Language, and Australian Aboriginal and Mayan Sign Languages—and communicating across different sign languages can be as difficult as it is across different spoken languages (Quinto-Pozos, 2008).

LANGUAGE IS RULE-GOVERNED

The only reason symbol-laden languages work at all is that people agree on how to use them. The linguistic agreements that make communication possible can be codified in rules. Languages contain several types of rules that continuously evolve (Garner, 2014). **Phonological rules** govern how sounds are combined to form words. For instance, the words *champagne*, *double*, and *occasion* have the same meanings in French as in English, but their pronunciations differ across the two languages because of differing phonological rules.

Whereas phonological rules determine how spoken language sounds, **syntactic rules** govern the way symbols can be arranged. Notice that the following statements contain the same words, but the shift in syntax creates quite different meanings:

Whiskey makes you sick when you're well.

Whiskey, when you're sick, makes you well.

Although most of us aren't able to describe the syntactic rules that govern our language, it's easy to recognize their existence when they are violated. A humorous example is the way the character Yoda speaks in the *Star Wars* movies. Phrases such as “the dark side are they” or “your father he is” often elicit a chuckle because they bend syntactical norms. Sometimes, however, apparently ungrammatical speech is simply following a different set of syntactic rules, reflecting regional or co-cultural dialects. Linguists believe it is crucial to view such dialects as *different* rather than *deficient* forms of English (Wolfram & Schilling-Estes, 2005).

Media Clip

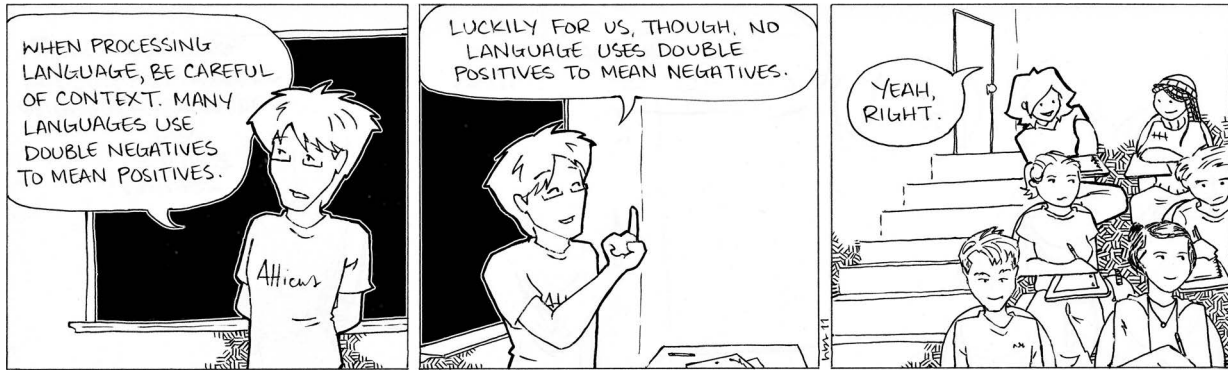


Invented Languages: Game of Thrones

When characters on the series *Game of Thrones* speak foreign-sounding words, they're not just spouting gibberish. The show commissioned linguist David J. Peterson to create actual languages for these scenes, including Dothraki and Valyrian. These languages follow the same rules—phonological, syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic—described in this section.

Peterson takes his job seriously. When he created the language Dothraki (which is spoken by a nomadic warrior tribe in the series), he mapped out the history of every word—including thousands of words that would never be needed on the show (Brennan, 2016). Peterson also developed complete languages for characters in shows such as *The 100* and *The Shannara Chronicles*.

If the idea of inventing a language seems odd, consider that you may have done so on a much smaller scale. If you have terms and phrases that you use with friends and loved ones that outsiders wouldn't understand, then you too have engaged in a form of language creation.



Semantic rules govern the meaning of language as opposed to its structure. These make it possible for us to agree that “bikes” are for riding and “books” are for reading. Without semantic rules, communication would be impossible; each of us would use symbols in unique ways, unintelligible to others.

Semantic rules help us understand the meaning of individual words, but they often don’t explain how language operates in everyday life. Consider the statement “Let’s get together tomorrow.” The semantic meaning of the words in this sentence is clear enough, yet the statement could be taken in several ways. It could be a straightforward invitation (“I hope we can get together”), a polite command (“I want to see you”), or an empty cliché (“I don’t really want to see you”). We learn to distinguish the accurate meanings of such speech acts through **pragmatic rules**, which tell us what uses and interpretations of a message are appropriate in a given context (Dougherty et al., 2009).

When all players understand and use the same pragmatic rules, smooth communication is possible. For example, one rule specifies that the relationship between communicators affects the meaning of a statement. The statement “I want to see you” is likely to mean one thing when uttered by your boss and another entirely when it comes from your lover. Likewise, the setting in which the statement is made plays a role: “I want to see you” will probably have a different meaning at the office than at a party. Of course, the nonverbal behaviors that accompany a statement also help us decode its meaning.

People in individual relationships create their own sets of pragmatic rules. Consider the use of humor: The teasing and jokes you exchange with gusto with one friend might be considered tasteless or offensive in another relationship. For instance, imagine an email message typed in CAPITAL LETTERS and filled with CURSE WORDS, INSULTS, NAME-CALLING, and EXCLAMATION MARKS!!! How would you interpret such a message? An outside observer might consider this an example of “flaming” and be appalled, when in fact the message might be a fun-loving case of “verbal jousting” between buddies (O’Sullivan & Flanagan, 2003; Maiz-Arevalo, 2015). If you have a good friend whom you call by a less-than-tasteful nickname as a term of endearment, then you understand the concept. Keep in mind, however, that those who aren’t privy

to your relationship's pragmatic rules are likely to misunderstand you, so you'll want to be wise about when and where to use these personal codes.

LANGUAGE IS SUBJECTIVE

If the rules of language were more precise and if everyone followed them, we would suffer from fewer misunderstandings. You have an hour-long argument about “feminism” only to discover that you each were using the term in different ways and that you really were in basic agreement. You tease a friend in what you mean to be a playful manner, but he takes you seriously and is offended.

These problems occur because people attach different meanings to the same message. Ogden and Richards (1923) illustrated this point in their well-known “triangle of meaning” (see Figure 5.2). This model shows that there is only an indirect relationship—indicated by a broken line—between a word and the thing or idea it represents.

Ogden and Richards's model is oversimplified in that not all words refer to physical things, or “referents.” For instance, some referents are abstract ideas (such as *love*), whereas others (such as *angry* or *exciting*) aren't even nouns. Despite these shortcomings, the triangle of meaning is useful because it clearly demonstrates an important principle: *Meanings are in people, not words*. Hence, an important task facing communicators is to establish a common understanding of the words they use to exchange messages. In this sense, communication—at least the effective kind—requires us to negotiate the meaning of our language (Leung & Lewkowicz, 2013). This brings us back to a familiar theme: Meaning is both *in* and *among* people. Language is a function of individuals who give each word unique meaning as well as cultures that create and share meaning collectively.

LANGUAGE AND WORLDVIEW

For more than 150 years, theorists have put forth the notion of **linguistic relativity**—that a language both reflects and shapes the worldview of those who use it (Deutscher, 2010; Everett, 2013). For instance, bilingual speakers seem to think differently when they change languages (Cook & Bassetti, 2011). In one study, French Americans were asked to interpret a series of pictures. When they spoke in French, their descriptions were far more romantic and emotional than when they used English to describe the same kind of images. In Israel, both Muslim and Jewish students saw bigger distinctions between their group and “outsiders” when using their native language than when they spoke in English, a neutral tongue in this context. Examples such as these show the power of language to shape cultural identity—sometimes for better and sometimes for worse.

The best-known declaration of linguistic relativity is the **Sapir-Whorf hypothesis**, credited to Benjamin Whorf, an amateur linguist, and

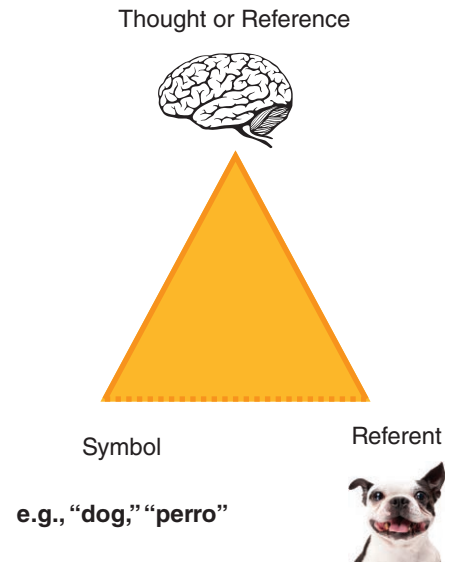
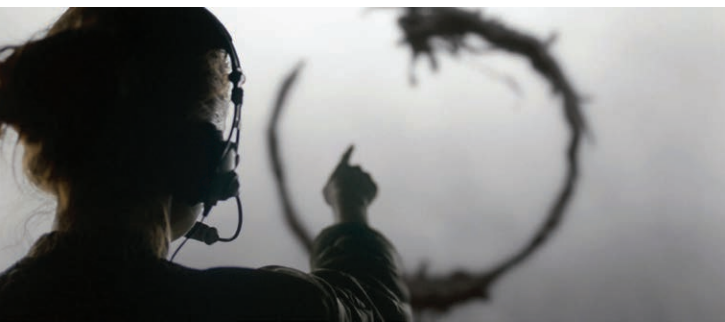


FIGURE 5.2 Ogden and Richards' Triangle of Meaning



The sci-fi film *Arrival* offers a dramatized illustration of the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis. By learning the language of extraterrestrial visitors, linguistics professor Louise Banks (Amy Adams) experiences the world in profoundly different ways. **Are you fluent in more than one language? If so, how does each one shape your worldview?**

anthropologist Edward Sapir (Tohidian, 2009; Whorf, 1956). Following Sapir's theoretical work, Whorf found that the language spoken by Hopi Native Americans represented a view of reality that is dramatically different from how speakers of other languages view the world. For example, the Hopi language makes no distinction between nouns and verbs. Therefore, the people who speak it describe the entire world as being constantly in process. Whereas English speakers use nouns to characterize people or objects as being fixed or constant, the Hopi language represents them more as verbs, constantly changing. In this sense, English represents the world rather like a collection of snapshots, whereas the Hopi representation is more like a movie.

Some languages contain terms that have no English equivalents (Wire, 2010). For example, consider a few words in other languages that have no simple translation in English:

- *Nemawashi* (Japanese): the process of informally feeling out the opinions of all the people involved with an issue before making a decision
- *Lagniappe* (French/Creole): an extra gift given in a transaction that wasn't expected by the terms of a contract
- *Lao* (Mandarin): respectful term used for older people, showing their importance in the family and in society
- *Dharma* (Sanskrit): each person's unique, ideal path in life and the knowledge of how to find it

It's possible to imagine concepts like these without having specific words to describe them, but linguistic relativity suggests that the terms do shape the thinking and actions of people who use them. Thus, speakers of a language that includes the notion of *lao* would probably be more inclined to treat their older members respectfully, and those who are familiar with *lagniappe* might be more generous.

The potential impact of linguistic relativity on interpersonal communication is significant. Consider the difference between the phrases "You make me angry" and "I get angry when you. . . ." The first phrase says to the other person—and to yourself—that your anger is the other person's fault. The second phrase is an "I" message that takes responsibility for your emotions (a concept described later in this chapter and also in Chapter 8). Changing your language can not only help reduce defensiveness in the other person, but it can also reframe how *you* see the situation. The same could happen if you begin calling adult females "women" instead of "girls" (Florio, 2016), or if you refer to college undergrads as "students" instead of "kids" (Valles, 2014). You might view those people differently based on the labels you use to describe them. Your words can affect how you see the world.

FOCUS ON RESEARCH

The Negative Consequences of Fat Talk

A premise of linguistic relativity is that our words don't just *reflect* how we see the world; they also *affect* how we see it. The language we use shapes our perception of things, others, and ourselves.

Communication researcher Analisa Arroyo found this principle at work in her study of "fat talk." People who regularly put concerns about their weight into words ("I'm so fat"; "My butt is huge") reinforce a poor body image. Arroyo identified three particular signs that fat talk is doing harm: (1) when it's used routinely and compulsively; (2) when it involves constant comparisons with others; and (3) when it includes guilt words such as "should" and "ought" ("I really should drop some weight").

As discussed in Chapter 3, a steady diet of negative self-appraisals and social comparison can turn into a destructive cycle of thoughts, words, and behaviors.

In an interesting twist, there seems to be no harm in *listening* to fat talk. Says Arroyo, "It is the act of engaging in fat talk, rather than passively being exposed to it, that has these negative effects." She suggests that people struggling with this problem should establish "fat talk free" weeks with their friends. Arroyo also believes that replacing "I should" with "I will" or "I can" when talking about weight reduction can help people move in the right direction.

Arroyo, A. (2013). "I'm so fat!" The negative outcomes of fat talk. *Communication Currents*, 7, 1–2.

Arroyo, A., & Harwood, J. (2012). Exploring the causes and consequences of fat talk. *Journal of Applied Communication Research*, 40, 167–187.

THE IMPACT OF LANGUAGE

As linguistic relativity suggests, language can have a strong influence on our perceptions and how we regard one another. In this section, we examine some of the many ways language can impact our lives.

NAMING AND IDENTITY

"What's in a name?" Juliet asked rhetorically. If Romeo had been a social scientist, he would have answered, "A great deal." Research has demonstrated that names are more than just a simple means of identification; they shape the way others think of us, the way we view ourselves, and the way we act (Lieberson, 2000).

For more than a century, researchers have studied the impact of rare and unusual names on the people who bear them (Christenfeld & Larsen, 2008). Early studies claimed that people with nonnormative names suffered everything from psychological and emotional disturbance to failure in college. Later studies show that people often have negative appraisals not only of unusual names, but also of unusual name spellings (e.g., Mehrabian, 2001). In one study, for example, people with unusual names were judged least likely to be hired (Cotton et al., 2008). Of course, what makes a name (and its spelling) unusual changes with time. In 1900, the 20 most popular names for baby girls in the United States included Bertha,



Baby naming is an important decision that can shape identity throughout life. **What consequences have flowed from having your name? How might things have been different if you had been given a dramatically different name?**

Mildred, and Ethel. By 2015, the top 20 names included Madison, Mia, and Sophia—names that would have been highly unusual a century earlier (Social Security Administration, 2016).

Some people regard unique names as distinctive. You can probably think of four or five unique names—of celebrities, sports stars, or even personal friends—that make the person easily recognizable and memorable. In one study, a poem signed with an unusual name was assessed as more creative than when signed by a more common name (Lebuda & Karwowski, 2013). Sometimes the choice of unique names is connected with cultural identity. For example, in some parts of the United States, nearly a third of African American girls born in the 1990s were given distinctively black names that belonged to no one else in the state (Dinwiddie-Boyd, 1994). Researchers suggest that distinctive names like these are a symbol of solidarity with the African American community. Conversely, choosing a less distinctive name can be a way of integrating the baby into the majority culture.

AFFILIATION

An impressive body of research shows how language can build and demonstrate solidarity with others. Communicators adapt their speech in a variety of ways to indicate affiliation and accommodation, including through their choice of vocabulary, rate of talking, number and placement of pauses, and level of politeness (Giles, 2016). In one study, the likelihood of mutual romantic interest increased when conversation partners' use of pronouns, articles, conjunctions, prepositions, and negations matched (Ireland et al., 2011). The same study revealed that when couples used similar language styles while instant messaging, the chances of their relationship continuing increased by almost 50 percent.

Close friends and lovers often develop a set of special terms that serve as a way of signifying their relationship (Dunleavy & Booth-Butterfield, 2009). Using the same vocabulary sets these people apart from others. The same process works among members of larger groups, from street gangs to military units. **Convergence** is the process of adapting one's speech style to match that of others with whom one wants to identify (Dragojevic et al., 2016). Language matching creates bonds not only between friends in person but also between strangers online (Rains, 2016; Riordan et al., 2013).

When two or more people feel equally positive about one another, their linguistic convergence will be mutual. But when one communicator wants or needs approval, convergence is more one-sided (Muir et al., 2016). We see this process when employees seeking advancement start speaking more like their superiors. One study even showed that adopting the swearing patterns of bosses and coworkers in emails is a sign that an employee is fitting into an organization's culture (Lublin, 2017). See the At Work sidebar in this section for a discussion of this topic.

The principle of speech accommodation works in reverse, too. Communicators who want to set themselves apart from others adopt the strategy of **divergence**, speaking in a way that emphasizes their differences (Gasiorek & Vincze, 2016). For example, members of an ethnic group might use their own dialect as a way of showing solidarity with one another. The same can occur across age lines, such as teens who adopt the slang of subcultures other than their own to show divergence from adults (Reyes, 2005).

Of course, communicators need to be careful about when—and when not—to converge their language. For example, using ethnic or racial epithets when you're not a member of that in-group may be inappropriate and even offensive (O'Dea et al., 2015). One of the pragmatic goals of divergence is the creation of norms about who may use certain words and who may not.

POWER AND POLITENESS

Communication researchers have identified a number of language patterns that communicate more or less power (Dillard, 2014; Hosman & Siltanen, 2006). Notice the difference between these two statements from an employee to a manager:

Excuse me, sir. I hate to say this, but I . . . uh . . . I guess I won't be able to finish the project on time. I had a personal emergency and . . . well . . . it was just impossible to finish it by today. I'll have it to you first thing on Monday, okay?

I won't be able to finish the project on time. I had a personal emergency and it was impossible to finish it by today. I will have it to you first thing on Monday.

The first statement is an example of what has been called **powerless language**: tentative and indirect word choices, with hedges and hesitations ("Excuse me, sir"; "I guess"; "okay?"). The second is labeled **powerful language**: direct and forceful word choices, with declarations and assertions ("I won't"; "I will"). Studies have shown that speakers who use powerful speech are rated as more competent, dynamic, and attractive than speakers who sound powerless (Ng & Bradac, 1993; Reid & Ng, 1999). In addition, when it comes to employment interview outcomes, a powerful speech style results in more positive attributions of competence and employability than a powerless one (Parton et al., 2002).

@work Swearing on the Job

Swearing serves a variety of communication functions (Baruch et al., 2017). It's a way to express emotions and to let others know how strongly you feel. It can be part of a compliment ("that was #\$\$@ing terrific!") or the worst of insults. Swearing can offend and alienate, but it can also build solidarity and be a term of endearment.

Communication researchers Danette Johnson and Nicole Lewis (2010) investigated the effects of swearing in work settings. Not surprisingly, they found that the more formal the situation, the more negative the appraisal. The chosen swear word also made a difference: "F-bombs" were rated as more inappropriate than other less-volatile terms. When hearers were surprised by a speaker's swearing, they were likely to deem the person as

incompetent—unless they were *pleasantly* surprised (Johnson, 2012).

Despite these findings, Stanford University professor Robert Sutton (2010) notes that choosing *not* to swear can actually violate the norms of some organizations. Moreover, he maintains that swearing on rare occasions can be effective for the shock value. (The fact that Sutton authored a book called *The No Asshole Rule* suggests he practices what he preaches.)

But even Sutton adds a cautionary note about swearing on the job: "If you are not sure, don't do it." The rules of interpersonal competence apply: Analyze and adapt to your audience, and engage in self-monitoring. And when in doubt, err on the side of restraint.

A *disclaimer* is a type of powerless speech that attempts to distance a speaker from remarks that might be unwelcome. For example, you might preface a critical message by saying, "I don't mean to sound judgmental, but . . ." and then go on to express your disapproval. One study showed that disclaimers actually *increase* negative judgments (El-Alayli et al., 2008). For instance, the phrase "I don't mean to sound arrogant" followed by a high-handed comment led subjects to regard the speaker as *more* arrogant. Disclaimers involving other negative qualities such as laziness and selfishness produced similar results. It seems that disclaimers backfire because they sensitize listeners to look for—and find—precisely the qualities that the speaker is trying to disavow.

Some scholars question the label "powerless" because tentative and indirect speech styles can sometimes achieve goals better than more assertive approaches (Lee & Pinker, 2010). For example, less forceful approaches can be attempts at **politeness**: communicating in ways that save face for both senders and receivers. Politeness is valued in some cultures more than others (Dunn, 2013). In Japan, saving face for others is an important goal, so communicators there tend to speak in ambiguous terms and use hedge words and qualifiers. In most Japanese sentences, the verb comes at the end of the sentence so the "action" part of the statement can be postponed. Traditional Mexican culture, with its strong emphasis on cooperation, also uses hedging to smooth over interpersonal relationships. By not taking a firm stand with their speech mannerisms, Mexicans believe they will not make others feel ill at ease.

Even in highly assertive cultures, simply counting the number of powerful or powerless statements won't always reveal who has the most control in a relationship. Social rules often mask the real distribution of power.

A boss who wants to be pleasant might say to a secretary, “Would you mind getting this file?” In truth, both boss and secretary know this is an order and not a request, but the questioning form makes the medicine less bitter. Sociolinguist Deborah Tannen (1994) describes how politeness can be a face-saving way of delivering an order:

I hear myself giving instructions to my assistants without actually issuing orders: “Maybe it would be a good idea to . . .”; “It would be great if you could . . .” all the while knowing that I expect them to do what I’ve asked right away. . . . This rarely creates problems, though, because the people who work for me know that there is only one reason I mention tasks—because I want them done. I *like* giving instructions in this way; it appeals to my sense of what it means to be a good person . . . taking others’ feelings into account. (p. 101)

As the proceeding quotation suggests, high-status speakers—especially higher-status women, according to Tannen—often realize that politeness is an effective way to get their needs met while protecting the dignity of the less-powerful person. The importance of achieving both content and relational goals helps explain why a mixture of powerful and polite speech is usually most effective (Geddes, 1992). The key involves adapting your style to your conversational partner (Lloyd et al., 2010). If the other person is likely to perceive politeness as weakness, it may be necessary to shift to a more powerful speaking style. Conversely, if the person sees powerful speech as rude and insensitive, it might be best to use a more polite approach (Fandrich & Beck, 2012). As always, competent communication requires flexibility and adaptability.

SEXISM AND RACISM

Sexist language “includes words, phrases, and expressions that unnecessarily differentiate between females and males *or* exclude, trivialize, or diminish” either sex (Parks & Roberton, 2000, p. 415). This type of speech can affect the self-concepts of women and men, which is why one author (Lillian, 2007) argues that it is a form of hate speech.

DARK SIDE OF COMMUNICATION

Sorry, Not Sorry

On the surface, saying “I’m sorry” seems like a good communication practice. Indeed, Chapter 9 describes the importance of apologies and forgiveness in interpersonal relationships.

But scholars (Schumann & Ross, 2010) and social commentators note that women say “I’m sorry” far more than men do, often out of habit (“I’m sorry, may I sit here?”; “I’m sorry, could you please tell me. . .”). Although these ritual apologies are attempts to be polite, they can suggest weakness and even subservience. “*Sorry* is simply another way of downplaying our power, of softening what we do, to seem nice,” observes Jessica Bennett (2014). “And yet, how can we be deemed likable and competent if we’re always sounding defensive or unsure?”

The Pantene ad *Not Sorry* and a skit by comedian Amy Schumer offer serious and humorous commentaries about women’s tendency to over-apologize. These videos are linked in an op-ed piece by Sloane Crosley (2015), who believes women should heighten their awareness of this issue and change the way they talk: “The *sorrys* are taking up airtime that should be used for making logical, declarative statements, expressing opinions and relaying impressions of what we want.”

Of course, there are times when saying “I’m sorry” is gracious, responsible, and altogether appropriate. Competent communicators will want to monitor how often they use the phrase and how necessary it is to say it—and adapt their language accordingly.

ASSESSING YOUR COMMUNICATION

Sexist Language

SECTION I:

For each of the following statements, rate your agreement or disagreement on a scale ranging from 1 to 5, where 1 = "strongly disagree" and 5 = "strongly agree."

- _____ 1. Women who think that being called a "chairman" is sexist are misinterpreting the word "chairman."
- _____ 2. Worrying about sexist language is a trivial activity.
- _____ 3. If the original meaning of the word "he" was "person," we should continue to use "he" to refer to both males and females today.
- _____ 4. The elimination of sexist language is an important goal.
- _____ 5. Sexist language is related to sexist treatment of people in society.
- _____ 6. When teachers talk about the history of the United States, they should change expressions, such as "our forefathers" to expressions that include women.
- _____ 7. Teachers who require students to use nonsexist language are unfairly forcing their political views on their students.

SECTION II:

For each of the following situations, rate your willingness on a scale ranging from 1 to 5, where 1 = very unwilling and 5 = very willing.

- _____ 8. When you are referring to a married woman, how willing are you to use the title "Ms. Smith" rather than "Mrs. Smith"?
- _____ 9. How willing are you to use the word "server" rather than "waiter" or "waitress"?
- _____ 10. How willing are you to use the expression "husband and wife" rather than "man and wife"?
- _____ 11. How willing are you to use the title "flight attendant" instead of "steward" or "stewardess"?

This self-assessment contains 11 of the 21 items on the Inventory of Attitudes Toward Sexist/Nonsexist Language-General, developed by Parks and Robertson (2000).

For scoring information, see page 163 at the end of the chapter.

Suzanne Romaine (1999) offers several examples of how linguistic terms can subtly stereotype men and women. To say that a woman *mothered* her children focuses on her nurturing behavior, but to say that a man *fathered* a child talks only about his biological role. We are familiar with terms such as *working mother*, but there is no term *working father* because we assume (perhaps inaccurately) that men are the breadwinners.

Beyond just stereotyping, sexist language can stigmatize women. For example, the term *unmarried mother* is common, but we do not talk about *unmarried fathers* because for many people there is no stigma attached to this status for men. Whereas there are over 200 English words for promiscuous women, there are only 20 for men (Piercey, 2000). Perhaps that's why "attitude towards women" is a significant predictor of attitudes regarding nonsexist language (Parks & Robertson, 2008). Education and perspective taking are also positively related to mindsets about inclusive language.

There are at least two ways to eliminate sexist language (Lei, 2006; Rakow, 1992). The first circumvents the problem altogether by eliminating sex-specific terms or substituting neutral terms. For example, using the plural *they* eliminates the necessity for *he*, *she*, *she and he*, or *he and she*. In fact, "they" has become the pronoun of choice for many individuals (Hess, 2016). When no sex reference is appropriate, you can substitute neutral terms. For example, *mankind* may be replaced with *humanity*, *human beings*, *human race*, and *people*; *manmade* may be replaced with *artificial*, *manufactured*, and *synthetic*; *manpower* may be replaced with *labor*, *workers*, and *workforce*; and *manhood* may be replaced with *adulthood*. In the same way, *Congressmen* and *Congresswomen* are *members of Congress*; *firemen* and *firewomen* are *firefighters*; *chairmen* and *chairwomen* are *presiding officers*, *leaders*, and *chairs*; *foremen* and *forewomen* are *supervisors*; *policemen* and *policewomen* are both *police officers*; and *stewardesses* and *stewards* are both *flight attendants*. Of course, some terms refer to things that could not possibly have a sex—so, for example, a *manhole cover* is a *sewer lid*.

The second method for eliminating sexism is to mark sex clearly—to heighten awareness of whether the reference is to a female or a male. For example, rather than substitute *chairperson* for *chairman*, use the terms *chairman* and *chairwoman* to specify whether the person is a man or a woman. (Note, also, that there is nothing sacred about putting *he* before *she*; in fact, putting *she*, *her*, and *hers* after *he*, *him*, and *his*, without changing the order, continues to imply that males are the more important sex and should come first.)

Whereas sexist language usually defines the world as made up of superior men and inferior women, **racist language** reflects a worldview that classifies members of one racial group as superior and others as inferior (Asante, 2002). Not all language that might have racist overtones is deliberate. For example, the connotations of many words favor whites over people of color (Smith-McLallen et al., 2006):

In the United States and many other cultures, the color white often carries more positive connotations than the color black. . . . Terms such as "Black Monday," "Black Plague," "black cats," and the "black market" all have negative connotations, and literature, television, and movies have traditionally portrayed heroes in white and villains in black. The empirical work of John E. Williams and others throughout the 1960s demonstrated that these positive and negative associations with the colors black and white, independent of any explicit connection to race, were evident among white and black children as young as 3 years old . . . as well as among adults. (pp. 47–48)

An obvious step toward eliminating racist language is to make sure your communication is free of offensive labels and slurs (Guerin, 2003). Some troublesome language will be easy to identify, whereas other problematic uses will be subtler. For instance, you may be unaware of using racial and ethnic modifiers when describing others, such as “black professor” or “Pakistani merchant” (or modifiers identifying sex, such as “female doctor” or “male secretary”). Modifiers such as these usually aren’t necessary, and they can be subtle indicators of racism/sexism. If you wouldn’t typically use the phrases “white professor,” “European American merchant,” “male doctor,” or “female secretary,” then modifiers that identify race and sex might be indicators of attitudes and language that need to be changed.

PRECISION AND VAGUENESS

Most people assume that the goal of language is to make our ideas clear to one another. When clarity is the goal, we need language skills to make our ideas understandable to others. Sometimes, however, we want to be less than perfectly clear. In the following pages, we point out some cases where vagueness serves useful purposes as well as cases where complete understanding is the goal.

Ambiguous Language

Ambiguous language consists of words and phrases that have more than one commonly accepted definition. Some ambiguous language is amusing, as the following newspaper headlines illustrate:

Police Begin Campaign to Run Down Jaywalkers
Teacher Strikes Idle Kids
20-Year Friendship Ends at the Altar



Sometimes ambiguous language can lead to humorous misunderstandings. In other cases, though, the confusion can be more serious. **How can you make sure your words don't create problems?**

Many misunderstandings that arise from ambiguity are trivial. We recall eating dinner at a Mexican restaurant and ordering a “tostada with beans.” Instead of being served a beef tostada with beans on the side, we were surprised to see the waiter bring us a plate containing a tostada *filled* with beans. Other misunderstandings involving ambiguous messages can be more serious. A nurse gave one of her patients a scare when she told him that he “wouldn’t be needing” his robe, books, and shaving materials anymore. The patient became quiet and moody. When the nurse inquired about the odd behavior, she discovered that the poor man had interpreted her statement to mean he was going to die soon. In fact, the nurse meant he would be going home shortly.

It’s difficult to catch and clarify every instance of ambiguous language. For this reason, the responsibility for interpreting statements accurately rests in large part with the receiver. Seeking feedback of one sort or another—for example, by paraphrasing and questioning—can help clear up misunderstandings: “You say you love me, but you want to see other people. In my book, ‘love’ is exclusive. What about you?”

Abstraction

Abstractions are convenient ways of generalizing about similarities between several objects, people, ideas, or events. Figure 5.3 is an **abstraction ladder** that shows how we can use a range of specific to abstract terms for describing an object, event, or situation.

We use higher-level abstractions all the time. For instance, rather than saying “Thanks for washing the dishes, vacuuming the rug, and making the bed,” we might more abstractly say “Thanks for cleaning up.” In such everyday situations, abstractions can be a useful kind of verbal shorthand.

High-level abstractions can help communicators find face-saving ways to avoid confrontations and embarrassment (Eisenberg & Witten, 1987). If a friend apologizes for arriving late for a date, you can choose to brush off the incident instead of making it an issue by saying, “Don’t worry. It wasn’t the end of the world”—a true statement, but less specific than saying, “To tell you the truth, I was mad at the time, but I’ve cooled off now.” If your boss asks your opinion of a new idea that you think is weaker than your own approach, but you don’t want to disagree, you could respond with a higher-level abstraction by saying, “I never thought of it that way.”

Although vagueness does have its uses, highly abstract language can cause several types of problems. At the most basic level, the vagueness of some abstract language makes it hard to understand the meaning of a message. Telling the hairstylist “shorter” or “more casual” without providing more specific instructions might lead to an unpleasant surprise. Overly abstract language can also lead to stereotyping if, for instance, someone who has had one bad experience blames an entire group: “Marriage counselors are worthless”; “New Yorkers are all rude”; or “Men are no good.” Overly abstract expressions such as these can cause people to think in problematic generalities, ignoring uniqueness.

You might assume that abstract statements will soften the blow of all critical messages, but research suggests that isn’t always the case. People who use vague language to describe others’ negative actions are rated as less likeable than those who use concrete language (Douglas & Sutton, 2010). By describing another’s negative behavior in abstract terms, you may appear to have a hidden agenda. The effect was not found, however, when describing the positive behaviors of others.

You can make your language—and your thinking—less abstract and more clear by learning to form *behavioral descriptions* of your problems, goals, appreciations, complaints, and requests. We use the word *behavioral* because such descriptions move down the abstraction ladder to describe the specific, observable objects and actions we’re thinking about. Table 5.1 shows how behavioral descriptions are much more clear and effective than vague, abstract statements.

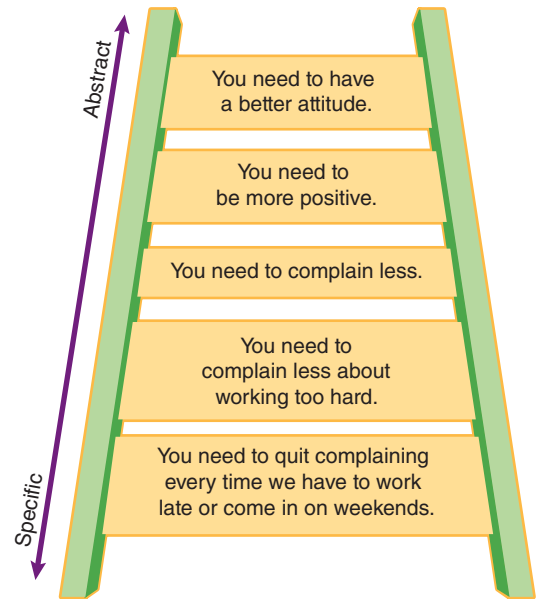
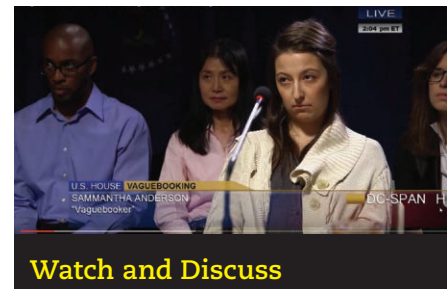


FIGURE 5.3 Abstraction Ladder. In this example, a boss gives feedback to an employee about career advancement at various levels of specificity.



Watch and Discuss

Look up and watch “Vague Facebook Posts—Congressional Hearings.”

- 1) Consider how “vaguebooking” uses *abstract* and *ambiguous* language to achieve its goals.
- 2) Discuss the pros and cons of being intentionally vague on social media posts.

TABLE 5.1 Abstract Versus Behavioral Descriptions

	Abstract Description	Behavioral Description			Remarks
		Who Is Involved	In What Circumstances	Specific Behaviors	
Problem	I'm no good at meeting strangers.	People I'd like to date	At parties and in school	I think, "They'd never want to date me." I don't initiate conversations.	Behavioral description more clearly identifies thoughts and behaviors to change.
Goal	I'd like to be more assertive.	Phone and door-to-door solicitors	When I don't want the product or can't afford it	Instead of apologizing, I want to keep saying "I'm not interested" until they go away.	Behavioral description clearly outlines how to act; abstract description doesn't.
Appreciation	"You've been a great boss."	[no clarification necessary]	When I've needed to change my schedule because of school exams or assignments	"You've been so willing to rearrange my work schedule."	Give both abstract and behavioral descriptions for best results.
Complaint	"I don't like some of the instructors around here."	Professors A and B	In class, when students ask questions the professors think are stupid	They either answer in a sarcastic voice (you might demonstrate) or accuse us of not studying hard enough.	If talking to A or B, use only behavioral descriptions. With others, use both abstract and behavioral descriptions.
Request	"Quit bothering me!"	My friends X and Y	When I'm studying for exams	"Instead of asking me again and again to party with you, I wish you'd accept that I need to study tonight."	Behavioral description will reduce defensiveness and make it clear that you don't always want to be left alone.

Euphemism

Euphemisms (from a Greek word meaning "to use words of good omen") are innocuous terms substituted for blunt ones. A euphemism avoids a direct, literal reference to an event (such as "She died"), substituting terms describing its consequences ("She's no longer with us"); related events ("She took her last breath"); metaphors ("She jumped the last hurdle"); or other, more abstract associations (McGlone et al., 2006). Euphemisms

are typically used to soften the impact of information that might be unpleasant, both for oneself as well as for the other person (McCallum & McGlone, 2011). It's easy to imagine how a relational breakup might be easier to handle with the explanation "I'm not ready for commitment" than with "I want to date other people." We tend to use euphemisms more when talking with people of higher status, probably as a way to avoid offending them (Makin, 2004). When choosing how to broach difficult subjects, the challenge is to be as kind as possible without sacrificing either your integrity or the clarity of your message.

Relative Language

Relative language gains meaning by comparison. For example, do you attend a large or a small school? This depends on what you compare it to. Alongside a campus such as Ohio State's, with more than 60,000 students, your school may look small; but compared with a college of 1,500 students, yours may seem quite large. Relative words such as *fast* and *slow*, *near* and *far*, and *short* and *long* are clearly defined only through comparison.

Using relative terms without explaining them can lead to communication problems. Have you ever responded to someone's question about the weather by saying it was warm, only to find out the person thought it was cold? Have you followed a friend's advice and gone to a "cheap" restaurant, only to find that it was twice as expensive as you expected? Have classes you heard were "easy" turned out to be hard? The problem in each case resulted from failing to link the relative word to a more measurable term.

One way to make words more measurable is to turn them into numbers. Health care practitioners have learned that patients often use vague wording when describing their pain: "It hurts a little"; "I'm pretty sore." The use of a numeric pain scale can give a more precise response—and lead to a better diagnosis (Prentice, 2005). When patients are asked to rank their pain from 1 to 10, with 10 being the most severe pain they've ever experienced, the number 7 is much more

Media Clip



Damning with Faint Praise: *Florence Foster Jenkins*

Florence Foster Jenkins (Meryl Streep) is a wealthy and well-connected socialite who has one remaining ambition in life: to share her singing talent with the world. Unfortunately, her vocal abilities are mediocre at best and ear-piercing at worst. But no one has the heart or courage to tell her.

Jenkins is surrounded with people who artfully dodge making blunt appraisals of her singing. Notice how her vocal coach uses abstract language in this exchange to avoid telling her the painful truth:

Coach: You've never sounded better.

Florence: Maestro, it is true that a lot of singers my age are on the decline, but I seem to get better and better.

Coach: I know, it's hard to believe, isn't it?

Florence: Well, I am so blessed.

Coach: There is no one quite like you.

Chapter 3 described how equivocation can be a strategy for evading the truth without technically lying. It's easy to understand why Jenkins's supporters choose this approach.

concrete and specific than “It aches a bit.” The same technique can be used when asking people to relate anything from the movies they’ve seen to their job satisfaction.

Evaluative Language

Evaluative language (sometimes also called *emotive language*) seems to describe something but really announces the speaker’s attitude toward it (Defour, 2008; Harding, 2007). If you approve of a friend’s roundabout approach to a difficult subject, you might call her “tactful”; if you don’t like it, you might accuse her of “beating around the bush.”

You can appreciate how evaluative words are really editorial statements when you consider these examples:

If You Approve, Say	If You Disapprove, Say
thrifty	cheap
traditional	old-fashioned
extrovert	loudmouth
cautious	coward
progressive	radical
information	propaganda
eccentric	crazy

THE LANGUAGE OF RESPONSIBILITY

Besides providing a way to make the content of a message clear or obscure, language reflects the speaker’s willingness to take responsibility for her or his beliefs, feelings, and actions. This acceptance or rejection of responsibility says a great deal about the speaker, and it can shape the tone of a relationship. To see how, read on.

“It” Statements

Notice the difference between the sentences in each set:

“It’s worrying when you’re late.”
 “I’m worried when you’re late.”

“It’s a bad idea.”
 “I don’t think that’s a good idea.”

“It’s a problem.”
 “I see it as a problem.”

As their name implies, **“it” statements** replace the personal pronouns *I* and *me* with the less immediate construction *it’s*. By contrast, **“I” language** clearly identifies the speaker as the source of a message. Communicators who use “it” statements avoid ownership of a message. This habit isn’t just

imprecise; it's a subtle, potentially unconscious way for someone to avoid taking a position.

"But" Statements

Statements that take the form "X-but-Y" can be quite confusing. A closer look at the **"but" statement** explains why. *But* has the effect of canceling the thought that precedes it:

"You're really a great person, but I think we ought to stop seeing each other."

"You've done good work for us, but we're going to have to let you go."

"This paper has some good ideas, but I'm giving it a grade of *D* because it's late."

"Buts" *can* be a face-saving strategy worth using at times. When the goal is to be absolutely clear, however, the most responsible approach will deliver the central idea without the distractions that can come with "but" statements. Break statements such as the preceding ones into two sentences, and then explain each one as necessary. Doing so lets you acknowledge both parts of the statement without contradicting yourself.

"I," "You," and "We" Language

We've already seen that "I" language is a way of accepting responsibility for a message. **"You" language**, by contrast, expresses a judgment of the other person. Positive judgments ("You did a great job!") rarely cause problems, but notice how each of the following critical "you" statements implies that the subject of the complaint is doing something wrong:

"You left this place a mess!"

"You didn't keep your promise!"

"You're really crude sometimes!"

"You" language is likely to arouse defensiveness. It implies that the speaker is qualified to judge the target—not an idea that most listeners are willing to accept. "I" language provides a more accurate and less provocative way to express a complaint (Simmons et al., 2005). By using "I" language, you can describe your reaction to someone's behavior, taking responsibility for your statement without expressing judgment. Communicators who use these kinds of "I" messages engage in **assertiveness**—clearly expressing their thoughts, feelings, and wants (Alberti & Emmons, 2008).

Assertive messages are composed of three different types of "I" statements. One describes the other person's behavior; one describes your feelings; and one describes the consequences the other's behavior has for you. Here are some examples of complete assertive messages:

"I get embarrassed [your feeling] when I hear you talk about my poor grades in front of our friends [the behavior you observed]. I'm afraid they'll think I'm stupid [the possible consequence]."

"Because I was waiting for you to pick me up this morning [behavior], I was late for class and wound up getting chewed out by the professor [consequences]. That's why I got so angry [feeling]."

“I haven’t been very affectionate [consequence] because I’ve noticed that you’ve hardly spent any time with me in the past few weeks [behavior]. I’m confused [feeling] about how you feel about me.”

When the chances of being misunderstood or getting a defensive reaction are high, it’s a good idea to include all three elements in your assertive message. In some cases, however, using only one or two of them will get the job done:

“I’m feeling annoyed because I went to a lot of trouble fixing this dinner, and now it’s cold.” [The behavior is obvious.]

“I’m worried because I haven’t heard from you.” [“Worried” is both a feeling and a consequence in this statement.]

Even the best-constructed and best-delivered “I” message won’t always receive a nondefensive response (Bippus & Young, 2005). As Thomas Gordon (1970) points out, “nobody welcomes hearing that his behavior is causing someone a problem, no matter how the message is phrased” (p. 145). Furthermore, “I” language in large doses can start to sound egotistical (Proctor, 1989). Research shows that self-absorbed people, also known as “conversational narcissists,” can be identified by their constant use of first-person singular pronouns (Vangelisti et al., 1990; Zimmermann et al., 2013). For this reason, “I” language works best in moderation.

One way to avoid overuse of “I” language is to consider the pronoun *we*. **“We” language** implies that the issue is the concern and responsibility of both the speaker and receiver of a message. Consider a few examples:

“We have a problem. We can’t seem to talk about money without fighting.”

“We aren’t doing a very good job of keeping the apartment clean, are we?”

“We need to talk to your parents about whether we’ll visit them for the holidays.”

“We” language can help build a constructive climate. It suggests a kind of “we’re in this together” orientation, a component of what is known as *verbal immediacy* (Turman, 2008). In one study (Fitzsimons & Kay, 2004), strangers who were required to use “we” instead of “you and I” in their interactions felt closer to one another after doing so. Couples who use “we” language are more satisfied and manage conflict better than those who rely more heavily on “I” and “you” pronouns (Seider et al., 2009). “We-talk” is also helpful for couples when one partner is dealing with a health issue (Rohrbaugh et al., 2012). Using plural pronouns suggests the medical problem is “ours” rather than “mine” or “yours.”

On the other hand, using the pronoun “we” can be presumptuous and even demanding because you are speaking for the other person as well as for yourself (Rentscher et al., 2013). It’s easy to imagine someone responding to the statement “We have a problem . . .” by saying “Maybe *you* have a problem, but don’t tell me *I* do!” Look again at the “we” language examples offered above and imagine that you don’t agree with the

TABLE 5.2 Pros, Cons, and Recommendations for Using “I,” “You,” and “We” Language

Pronoun	Pros	Cons	Recommendations
“I” Language	• Takes responsibility for personal thoughts, feelings, and wants. • Less defense provoking than evaluative “you” language.	• Can be perceived as egotistical, narcissistic, and self-absorbed.	• Use descriptive “I” messages in conflicts or confrontations when the other person does not perceive a problem. • Combine “I” with “we” language in conversations.
“You” Language	• Signals other-orientation, particularly when the topic is positive.	• Can sound evaluative and judgmental, particularly during confrontations.	• Avoid during confrontations. • Use “you” language when praising or including others.
“We” Language	• Signals inclusion, immediacy, cohesiveness, and commitment.	• Can speak improperly for others.	• Use in group settings to enhance sense of unity. • Avoid when expressing personal thoughts, feelings, and wants. • Combine with “I” language, particularly in personal conversations.

speaker’s conclusions. In that case, you would probably feel defensive rather than included.

As Table 5.2 summarizes, all three pronouns—*I*, *you*, and *we*—have their advantages and disadvantages. Given this fact, what advice can we give about the most effective pronouns to use in interpersonal communication? One study (Proctor & Wilcox, 1993) offers an answer. The researchers found that “I”/“we” combinations (e.g., “I think that we . . .” or “I would like to see us . . .”) were strongly endorsed by college students, particularly for confrontational conversations in romantic relationships (cf. Sendén et al., 2014). Richard Slatcher and his associates (2008) came to a similar conclusion: There is value in both “I” and “we” messages in relational communication, as these pronouns demonstrate both autonomy and connection (see Chapter 9 for a discussion of these relational dialectics).

Because too much of any pronoun comes across as inappropriate, combining pronouns is generally a good idea—and it suggests you’re able to see things from multiple perspectives (Pennebaker, 2011). If your “I” language reflects your position without being overly self-absorbed, your “you” language shows concern for others without judging them, and your “we” language includes others without speaking for them, you will probably come as close as possible to the ideal mix of pronouns.

GENDER AND LANGUAGE

So far we have discussed language usage as if it were identical for women and men. Are there differences between male and female language use? If so, how important are they?

EXTENT OF GENDER DIFFERENCES

Some people believe that men and women communicate in significantly different ways, whereas others find far more similarities than differences. We outline two approaches that represent two different sides in the gender and language debate.

Approach 1: Significant Differences

In 1992, John Gray argued that men and women are so fundamentally different that they might as well have come from separate planets. In his best-selling book *Men Are from Mars, Women Are from Venus*, he claimed:

Men and women differ in all areas of their lives. Not only do men and women communicate differently but they think, feel, perceive, react, respond, love, need, and appreciate differently. They almost seem to be from different planets, speaking different languages and needing different nourishment. (p. 5)

Gray's work is based largely on anecdotes and conjecture and lacks scholarly support. However, social scientists have acknowledged that there are some significant differences in the way men and women behave socially (Palomares, 2008; Wood & Fixmer-Oraiz, 2017). These findings have led some scholars to describe males and females as members of distinct cultures, with their differences arising primarily from socialization rather than biology. The best known advocate of this "two-culture" theory is sociolinguist Deborah Tannen (1990, 1994, 2001). She suggests that men and women grow up learning different rules about how to speak and act.

In support of the two-culture hypothesis, communication researcher Anthony Mulac (2006; see also Mulac et al., 2013) reports that men are more likely than women to speak in sentence fragments ("Nice photo."). Men more typically talk about themselves with "I" references ("I have a lot of meetings") and use more judgmental language. They are also more likely to make directive statements. By contrast, Mulac finds that female speech is more tentative, elaborate, and emotional. For instance, women's sentences are typically longer than men's. Women also make more reference to feelings and use intensive adverbs ("He's *really* interested") that paint a more complete verbal picture. In addition, female speech is often less assertive. It contains more statements of uncertainty ("It seems to be . . ."), hedges ("We're *kind of* set in our ways."), and tag questions ("Do you think so?"). Some theorists have argued that such differences cause women's speech to be less powerful, but more inclusive, than men's.

Communication scholar Julia Wood (Wood & Fixmer-Oraiz, 2017) has devoted much of her career to analyzing the impact of sex and gender

TABLE 5.3 Differences in Feminine and Masculine Communication Practices

Feminine	Masculine
Converse to maintain relationships	Converse to establish control
Create a climate of equality	Create a sense of power and status
Offer emotional support	Solve tasks and problems
Ask questions	Make statements
Offer concrete personal disclosures	Make abstract generalizations
Speak tentatively (often to be polite)	Speak assertively (often to be in charge)

Adapted from Wood, J. T., & Fixmer-Oraiz, N. (2017). *Gendered lives: Communication, gender, & culture* (12th ed.). Boston, MA: Cengage.

on communication. While she maintains that Gray’s “Mars and Venus” approach is an overstatement that can do more harm than good, she acknowledges there are differences in what she terms “feminine and masculine communication practices,” as summarized in Table 5.3.

Approach 2: Minor Differences

Despite the differences in the way men and women speak, the link between gender and language use isn’t as clear-cut as it might seem (Timmerman, 2002). One meta-analysis involving more than 3,000 participants found that women were only slightly more likely than men to use tentative speech (Leaper & Robnett, 2011). Three other analyses (Leaper & Ayres, 2007) looked for gender differences in adults’ talkativeness, affiliative speech, and assertive speech—and found negligible differences for all three language constructs. In essence, these studies showed that men’s and women’s speech are far more similar than different.

A recent study offers further support for the “minor differences” approach (Hancock et al., 2015). Researchers asked men and women to describe a health-related episode in their lives. Analysis of the transcripts revealed that women used slightly more intense adverbs and personal pronouns than men did. However, participants who read the transcripts were largely unable to identify the speaker’s gender. The same researchers then asked men, women, and transgender women to describe a painting. Studied closely, the transgender women’s word choices were slightly more similar to men’s than to women’s—but again, most people could not distinguish between them on the basis of word choice.

In light of the considerable similarities in language use across gender, communication researcher Kathryn Dindia (2006) suggests that the “men are from Mars, women are from Venus” claim should be replaced by the metaphor that “men are from North Dakota, women are from South Dakota.”



When occupational roles drive conversation, gender differences in language use can fade or disappear. ***Are there occasions in your life when the influence of gender disappears from your conversations?***

NON-GENDER INFLUENCES ON LANGUAGE USE

Gender isn't the only factor that influences how women and men use language. Other factors can outweigh, or at least mitigate, the influences of gender when it comes to language use.

Occupation is one such factor. As an example, male and female athletes communicate in similar ways (Sullivan, 2004). Male day care teachers' speech to their students resembles the language of female teachers more closely than it resembles the language of fathers at home (Gleason & Greif, 1983). Female farm operators, working in a male-dominated world, reproduce the masculinity that spells success for their male counterparts, swearing and talking "tough as nails" (Pilgeram, 2007).

Another factor that can trump gender is *power*. For instance, in gay and lesbian relationships, the conversational styles of partners are more strongly linked to power differences in the relationship (e.g., who is earning more money) than to gender (Steen & Schwartz, 1995). There are also few differences between the way men and women use threatening speech when they have the same amount of bargaining strength in a negotiation (Scudder & Andrews, 1995). Findings like these suggest that characteristically feminine or masculine speech has been less a function of gender or sex than of social power historically. In fact, differences in social status often show up more clearly in language than gender differences do (Pennebaker, 2011).

What then is the verdict on gender's effects on language? The simple answer is that there are some differences between male and female language patterns. However, those distinctions may not be as significant as some claim—and they might occur for reasons other than the gender or biological sex of the communicator. Language differences by gender are sometimes easier to spot and measure in online communication, as we discuss in the next section.

SOCIAL MEDIA AND LANGUAGE

The principles described so far in this chapter apply to language in both face-to-face interaction and mediated communication. However, researchers have begun to discover some unique dimensions of language as it is used in social media. In this section, we focus on two topics covered throughout this book—impression management and gender—and describe how they show up in online language choices.

ONLINE LANGUAGE AND IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT

As we noted in Chapter 3, much of online communication is an exercise in impression management. For example, text message errors can make the sender look bad to some recipients (such as professors, bosses, and

customers), so it's important to manage those impressions. One way to do so is by using a block signature indicating that a text message was typed on a mobile device (Carr & Stefaniak, 2012). Some texters' signatures point-blank say, "This was written on my cell phone, so please excuse the likely errors." This in essence shifts the blame for the mistakes from the message sender to the device.

Dating websites are all about impression management (Tomlinson, 2013). Subscribers to online dating services can manipulate not only their photos and videos but also their self-descriptions. Women are more likely than men to lie about their weight on dating sites, whereas men more often misrepresent their professions and income (Huestis, 2010). Even a person's first name can create an online impression (Gebauer et al., 2012). A German study found that men named Alexander were 102 percent more likely to get visits on a dating site than those named Kevin. (Although Kevin is a popular name in the United States, it is so unpopular in German-speaking countries that its negative appraisal is dubbed "Kevinism.")

Impression management isn't restricted to the search for romantic partners. Facebook friends also try to put their best foot forward with strategic language choices (Bazarova et al., 2012). They tend to use more positive emotion words in their public status updates, projecting an upbeat persona, than in private messages. In addition, Facebook users choose warmer language when posting on a close friend's wall than on a distant acquaintance's, indicating their friendship status to a larger audience.

FOCUS ON RESEARCH

The Language of Online Community

Wikipedia is more than just a free encyclopedia. It's also a community of editors and administrators who work together online, building relationships as they go. A team led by Daniela Iosub analyzed the contributors' "talk pages" to see what they reveal about the language patterns of the Wikipedia community.

The researchers collected data from nearly 12,000 contributors who had written at least 100 comments apiece on the English Wikipedia talk pages. After running the data through lexicon-based computer programs, the analysts drew conclusions related to status and gender.

Status: Administrators, who hold a higher rank than editors, tend to use more neutral, impersonal, and formal words. Editors, on the other hand, communicate more emotionally and relationally—that is, they use language to form and maintain connections

with each other. An administrator might say, "That idea has merit." An editor might phrase it this way: "I really like your suggestion."

Gender: Compared with male contributors, women tend to communicate in ways that promote social and emotional connection ("We're making good progress—thanks for your input"), regardless of their status in the community. Female editors are the most relationship-oriented, whereas male administrators are the least.

The researchers suggest that if the Wikipedia community wants to grow, its administrators would do well to adopt a more relational style of communicating. One way to achieve this would be to increase the number of female administrators. An alternative would be for male contributors to develop a warmer, more personal style—because that helps build community.

Iosub, D., Laniado, D., Castillo, C., Morell, M. F., & Kaltenbrunner, A. (2014). Emotions under discussion: Gender, status and communication in online collaboration. *PLoS ONE*, 9, e104880.

Although email has become a less popular means of online communication, it's still a mainstay in the business world. Executives acknowledge that they attempt to manage impressions in the way they craft their emails (Caron et al., 2013). For instance, their professional messages are less formal when written on smartphones than on office computers. Those sent from mobile devices often begin without a salutation and go straight into business talk. When written from an office computer, they tend to start with a greeting and first name ("Hello, Mary"). Email closings follow a similar pattern. Executives say this isn't an accident—when communicating by smartphone, they want to give the impression that they are busy and "don't have time to be friendly."

ONLINE LANGUAGE AND GENDER

Research shows that men and women have different written language styles (Pennebaker, 2011), which shows up in online communication (Hosseini & Tammimy, 2016). For instance, men tend to use more large words, nouns, and swear words than women do. By contrast, women use more personal pronouns, verbs, and hedge phrases (e.g., "I think"). Of course, word count doesn't tell the whole story. For instance, whereas women and men use the word "we" about equally, they do so in different ways. Closer scrutiny suggests that women are more likely to use what's known as the "warm we" ("We have so much fun together"), while men are more inclined toward the "distant we" ("We need to do something about this."). Although there are indeed gender differences in written language usage, they aren't absolute. Computer programs can correctly identify the sex of an author 67 to 72 percent of the time (50 percent is chance).

Data gathered from social networking sites show even greater distinctions. In one study, researchers analyzed more than 15 million Facebook status updates from approximately 75,000 volunteers over a 34-month period (Schwartz et al., 2013). There were marked differences in male and female language use (and also between people of different ages and personalities). Women used more emotion words ("excited"; "wonderful") and first-person singular pronouns, and they made more references to the people in their lives. Men made more object references ("game";



“government”; “Xbox”) and swore far more often—a finding that seems to hold true across every study conducted about male and female word use.

It appears that people are intuitively aware of gender differences in online language. For instance, one study found that online communicators adopt different writing styles depending on their online gender identities (Palomares & Lee, 2010). Participants were given randomly selected gendered avatars—some matching their biological sex, some not. Communicators who were assigned feminine avatars expressed more emotion, made more apologies, and used more tentative language than did those with masculine avatars. In other words, participants adapted their language to match linguistic gender stereotypes.

Online language differences between the sexes are more pronounced among adolescents. A study looked at the word choices of teenage boys and girls in chat rooms (Kapidzic & Herring, 2011). The boys were more active and assertive, initiating interaction and making proposals, whereas the girls were more reactive (“wow”; “omg”; “lmao”). The boys were also more flirtatious and sexual (“any hotties wanna chat?”). The researchers noted that these accentuated differences were probably due to the age of the participants and that some of the distinctions would likely recede in adulthood.

It’s important to remember that the words you use online say a lot about you. They reflect who you are and how you feel about others. And keep in mind that online messages can be recorded and saved. They can leave lasting reminders of your affinity for others, or they might come back to haunt you. As is true of face-to-face interaction, choose and use your words carefully.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Objective 5.1 Explain the symbolic, rule-based, subjective, culture-bound nature of language.

Language is both a marvelous communication tool and the source of many interpersonal problems. Every language is a collection of symbols governed by a variety of rules. Because of its symbolic nature, language is not a precise vehicle; its meanings rest in people, not in words themselves. Finally, the very language we speak can shape our worldview.

Q: Describe how a recent, important communicative exchange from your life illustrates the symbolic, rule-based, subjective, culture-bound nature of language.

Objective 5.2 Recognize the impact, both positive and negative, of language in interpersonal relationships.

Language both reflects and shapes the perceptions of its users. For example, names that people are given can influence their identity and the way they are viewed by others. Language also reflects the level of affiliation communicators have with each other. And language patterns reflect and shape a speaker’s perceived power. Finally, language can reflect and influence sexist and racist attitudes.

When used carelessly, language can lead to a variety of interpersonal problems. The level of precision or vagueness of messages can affect a receiver’s

understanding of them. Both precise messages and vague, evasive messages have their uses in interpersonal relationships; and a competent communicator has the ability to choose the optimal level of precision for the situation at hand. Competent communicators also know how to use “I,” “you,” and “we” statements to accept the optimal level of responsibility and relational harmony. Using emotive terms can lead to unnecessary disharmony in interpersonal relationships.

Q: Analyze your language use over two days to identify both how it facilitates relationships and how it creates interpersonal problems.

Objective 5.3 Describe the influence gender has on language use in interpersonal relationships.

The relationship between gender and language is a complex one. Although some writers in the popular press have argued that men and women are radically different and thus speak different languages, this position isn’t supported by scholarship.

A growing body of research suggests that what differences do exist are relatively minor in light of the similarities between the sexes. Many of the language differences that first appear to be sex-related may actually be due to other factors such as occupation and interpersonal power.

Q: Identify similarities and differences in male and female language use, and provide explanations for such differences.

Objective 5.4 Identify ways in which online language usage is different from the in-person variety.

Language use in social media has some distinct features. Word choice is an important component of online impression management. Gender differences are also more pronounced (or at least more measurable) when written via social media.

Q: Analyze your social media messages to see whether they reflect the identity you wish to project.

KEY TERMS

Abstraction ladder (149)
Ambiguous language (148)
Assertiveness (153)
“But” statement (153)
Convergence (142)
Divergence (143)
Euphemism (150)
Evaluative language (152)

“I” language (152)
“It” statement (152)
Linguistic relativity (139)
Phonological rules (137)
Politeness (144)
Powerful language (143)
Powerless language (143)
Pragmatic rules (138)

Racist language (147)
Relative language (151)
Sapir–Whorf hypothesis (139)
Semantic rules (138)
Sexist language (145)
Syntactic rules (137)
“We” language (154)
“You” language (153)

ACTIVITIES

1. Working with a group of classmates, describe one syntactic, one semantic, and one pragmatic rule for each situation:

- Asking an acquaintance out for a first date.
- Declining an invitation to a party.
- Responding to a stranger who has just said “excuse me” after bumping into you in a crowd.

2. The information about the impact of language on pages 141–155 shows how the words a communicator chooses can shape others’ perceptions. Create and present to your class two scenarios for each type of linguistic influence in the following list. The first should describe how the type of influence could be used constructively, and the

second should describe an unethical application of this knowledge.

- a. Naming and identity
- b. Affiliation
- c. Power
- d. Sexism and racism

3. Translate the following into behavioral language and share with your classmates to get their feedback.

- a. An abstract goal for improving your interpersonal communication (e.g., “Be more assertive” or “Stop being so sarcastic”).
- b. A complaint you have about another person (for instance, that he or she is “selfish” or “insensitive”).

In both cases, describe the person or people involved, the circumstances in which the communication will take place, and the precise behaviors involved. What difference will using the behavioral descriptions be likely to make in your relationships?

4. With a group of classmates, practice rephrasing each of the following “you” statements in “I” and/or “we” language:

“You’re not telling me the truth!”

“You only think of yourself!”

“Don’t be so touchy!”

“You don’t understand a word I’m saying!”

Now think of three “you” statements you could make to people in your life. Transform each of these statements into “I” and “we” language, and rehearse them with a classmate.

5. Some authors believe that differences between male and female communication are so great that they can be characterized as “men are from Mars, women are from Venus.” Other researchers believe the differences aren’t nearly so dramatic and would describe them as “men are from North Dakota, women are from South Dakota.” Which approach seems more accurate to you? Offer experiences from your life to support your point of view.

6. Do you communicate differently online or by text than in person? Does your social media language differ depending on the medium you use? Monitor your communication over three days and see if you “talk” distinctly in text messages, social networking posts, tweets, and blog entries compared with face-to-face communication. Are there some words you’re more prone to use on Facebook, for example, than in person?

SCORING FOR ASSESSING YOUR COMMUNICATION (PAGE 146)

Add your responses to the 11 statements, making sure to reverse-score statements 1, 2, and 3 (if you indicated 5, change it to 1; change 4 to 2; change 2 to 4; and change 1 to 5). Scores can range from 11 to 55. Scores that are 38 or higher reflect a supportive attitude toward nonsexist language; scores between 11 and 27 reflect a negative attitude toward nonsexist language; and scores between 28 and 37 reflect a neutral attitude. Scholars note that women are typically less tolerant of sexist language than are men, which may have an impact on these scores (Douglas & Sutton, 2014).